

● HARD

● EXPRESSION OF IDEAS

● ANSWER KEY

Rhetorical Synthesis

05

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ANSWER KEY · SAT QUESTION BANK

2026-05-29

Q1**C**

- C. According to Stewart, a “clash of cultures” between Athens and Sparta caused the conflict, not Athens’s rise.
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Choice C is the best answer. Using a quotation from Stewart, the sentence challenges Thucydides’s explanation that the rise of Athens caused the conflict, suggesting that it was instead caused by a “clash of cultures.”

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence uses a quotation, the quotation doesn’t challenge Thucydides’s explanation of the conflict. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence mentions that Stewart challenged Thucydides’s explanation of the conflict, it doesn’t use a quotation to challenge Thucydides’s explanation: the quoted word “inevitable” is from Thucydides. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence appears to refute Thucydides’s explanation, it does so in a way that misrepresents the information in the notes; Allison’s Thucydides trap theory is based on Thucydides’s explanation of the conflict. Thus, Allison’s theory affirms, rather than challenges, Thucydides’s explanation.

Q2

C

- C. Docked programs are more resource-intensive than dockless programs, but they avoid some of the latter’s organizational challenges.
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Choice C is the best answer. The sentence compares some disadvantages of docked and dockless bike-share programs, explaining that while docked programs are more resource-intensive (requiring significant space and money), dockless programs have greater organizational challenges.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence compares dockless programs to docked programs, noting an advantage of docked programs: they offer order and consistency. It doesn’t compare disadvantages of the two types of programs. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence compares dockless programs to docked programs, noting an advantage of dockless programs: they are easy and inexpensive to implement. However, it misrepresents information from the notes, stating that dockless programs are less flexible than docked programs. In addition, it doesn’t compare disadvantages of the two types of programs. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes an advantage of dockless programs, then makes a general statement that applies to both types of programs; it doesn’t compare disadvantages of the two types of programs.

Q3

B

- B. As a sestina, “Towards Autumn” contains thirty-nine lines and six end words—in this case, *daughter*, *friend*, *bread*, *mother*, *lover*, and *myself*—that alternate in a set pattern.
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Choice B is the best answer. The sentence uses the poem “Towards Autumn” to illustrate the form of a sestina, explaining that a sestina’s thirty-nine lines all end in one of six alternating words and showcasing that poem’s specific end words.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence identifies both of Hacker’s poems as sestinas; it doesn’t use one of the poems to illustrate the form of a sestina. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence appears to use the poem “Forage Sestina” to illustrate a feature of the sestina form, it misrepresents the information in the notes. According to the notes, “Forage Sestina” doesn’t use these six end words; it uses six other words instead. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence uses the poem “Towards Autumn” as an example of one of Hacker’s sestinas, it misrepresents the information in the notes. According to the notes, “Towards Autumn” doesn’t use these six end words; it uses six other words instead.

Q4

C

- C. After evaluating dozens of CMN studies, Karst and colleagues expressed concern that recent claims about common mycorrhizal networks are “disconnected from evidence.”
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Choice C is the best answer. This choice uses a quotation to convey the authors’ criticism and challenge to the wood-wide web theory due to an absence of evidence.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn’t emphasize a potential problem with the wood-wide web theory. It uses a quotation to introduce the theory and its originator. It doesn’t mention any criticism or challenge to the theory. Choice B is incorrect. This choice uses a quotation, but it doesn’t emphasize a potential problem with the wood-wide web theory. It uses a quotation to describe the appeal and interest of the theory, but it doesn’t indicate why the authors are concerned or what evidence they have. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t use a quotation at all. It paraphrases the main idea of the 2022 study, but it doesn’t include any specific words or phrases from the notes. It also doesn’t emphasize a potential problem with the theory, but rather its popularity.

Notes

Accept equivalent forms (e.g. $0.25 \equiv 1/4$). For grid-in items, decimal and fraction answers are both valid.

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